

Autonomy Of Local Assembly

doc-autonomy-of-local-assembly

Ecclesiology · Nature of the Church · doctrine · divided_lineages · brethren distinctive

DISPUTED

score 0.725
confidence medium

Statement under examination

Each local assembly is autonomous under Christ's headship, governed by its own elders, not subordinate to a denominational hierarchy or external bishop.

In plain language

The Greek behind these passages gives a clear, consistent picture for one half of the question. In Acts 14:23 Paul and Barnabas appoint elders church by church, and in Titus 1:5 Titus appoints elders city by city. The same small word 'throughout/by' (kata) distributes a group of elders, never a single ruler, across each town. In Acts 20 the very men called 'elders' (presbyterous) in verse 17 are called 'overseers' (episkopous) in verse 28, so elder and overseer are two names for one office, and they shepherd the flock of God in their own city. First Peter 5 agrees: the writer calls himself a 'fellow elder' (sympresbyteros, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), not a bishop above the elders; the elders shepherd the flock that is among them; they must not lord it over the people; and Christ alone is named the 'Chief Shepherd' (archipomen, also a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) over them all. That much the words support strongly. What the words cannot prove is the second half, that no wider authority exists. The same verb that tells Titus to appoint local elders, 'to direct/prescribe' (diatasso), is the verb Paul uses when he says he gives the same order in all the churches in 1 Corinthians 7:17, and again for the offering across many churches. In Acts 16:4 'decrees' (dogmata) decided by the apostles and elders at Jerusalem are carried to the local churches, city by city, to keep. The word 'assembly/church' (ekklesia) itself names both a single local assembly, like the church of Ephesus or each of the seven churches in Revelation, and one larger church that Christ builds. Because the same authority words and the same word for church reach both the local and the wider level, the text settles who governs a congregation locally but does not rank a fully independent model against a connected one. For that reason this proposition is best recorded as genuinely contested, well grounded in its positive half, unsettled in its negative half.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0750	ἀρχιποίμην	archipoimēn	chief shepherd	1
G1299	διατάσσω	diatassō	to direct	16
G1378	δόγμα	dogma	decree	5
G1577	ἐκκλησία	ekklēsia	assembly	114
G1985	ἐπίσκοπος	episkopos	overseer	5
G2525	καθίστημι	kathistēmi	to appoint/conduct	21
G2596	κατά	kata	according to	477
G2634	κατακυριεύω	katakyrieuō	to master	4
G2819	κλήρος	klēros	lot	

G2919	κρίνω	krinō	to judge	
G4165	ποιμαίνω	poimainō	to shepherd	11
G4168	ποίμνιον	poimnion	flock	5
G4172	πόλις	polis	city	
G4245	πρεσβύτερος	presbyteros	elder	66
G4850	συμπρεσβύτερος	sympresbyteros	fellow elder	1
G5500	χειροτονέω	cheirotoneō	to appoint	2

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

Direct queries confirm the positive half of the proposition with grammatical precision. Each local body receives its own plurality of elders, distributively (Acts 14:23 reads 'having appointed' (cheirotoneo, G5500) 'elders' (presbyterous, G4245) plural with 'in every church' (kat' ekklesian); Titus 1:5 reads 'elders' (presbyterous) 'city by city' (kata polin)), and the same plural cohort named 'elders' (presbyterous, G4245) in Acts 20:17 is renamed 'overseers' (episkopous, G1985) in Acts 20:28, so elder and overseer are one office over one local flock, with Christ alone as 'Chief Shepherd' (archipoimen, G0750), a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), in 1 Peter 5:4. What the lexicon does not establish is the negative claim of non-subordination. The very verb of Titus 1:5's local directive, 'I prescribe/direct' (diatasso, G1299), is the verb Paul applies to all the churches at once in 1 Corinthians 7:17 ('in all the churches I prescribe', en tais ekklesiis pasais diatassomai) and 1 Corinthians 16:1, and at Acts 16:4 binding 'decrees' (dogmata, G1378) that have been 'decided' (kekrimena, from G2919) from the Jerusalem assembly are delivered to the local churches 'throughout the cities' (kata tas poleis) to keep. Because 'assembly/church' (ekklesia, G1577) itself denotes both the single local assembly and the one supra-local (spanning beyond one place) church, and the same authority vocabulary reaches both levels, the polity (church-government) scope is materially contested and the verdict is recorded as disputed.

Scripture

Acts.14.23 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G5500 χειροτονέω, G4245 πρεσβύτερος, G2596 κατά, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Force. Queried morphology (word-form analysis) reads 'having appointed' (cheirotoneo, G5500, an aorist active participle, that is a completed past action in participle form) 'elders' (presbyterous, G4245, accusative plural, the noun in the direct-object form) 'in every church' (kat' ekklesian, G2596 preposition, distributive sense meaning 'one set in each'). The preposition 'according to/throughout' (kata) here is distributive, placing a plurality of elders in each individual congregation. The grammar secures local elder governance but is silent about any higher coordinating structure either way. The verb 'to appoint/elect' (cheirotoneo) is rare: only one other genuine occurrence (2 Corinthians 8:19), where a man is chosen by the churches plural for the collection, so the appointment verb itself appears in a trans-local (across multiple churches) coordination setting too.

Titus.1.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2525 καθίστημι, G4245 πρεσβύτερος, G2596 κατά, G1299 διατάσσω, G4172 πόλις

Force. Titus is to 'appoint/install' (katasteses, from kathistemi, G2525) 'elders' (presbyterous) 'city by city' (kata polin, G2596 plus G4172), the same distributive 'throughout' (kata) as Acts 14:23, grounding a local plurality per town. Decisively, the verse states the appointment proceeds because Paul 'directed/ordered' (diataxamen, from diatasso, G1299, first person singular, 'I directed'). The identical verb 'to direct/prescribe' (diatasso, G1299) reappears in 1 Corinthians 7:17 directed at all the churches, so the very word that authorizes local elders is also the word for trans-local (across many churches) apostolic ordering. This is why the verse simultaneously supports local elders and complicates a strict no-external-authority reading.

Acts.20.17 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4245 πρεσβύτερος, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Force. Paul summons the 'elders' (presbyterous, G4245, accusative plural, the direct-object form) of 'the church/assembly' (tes ekklesias, G1577, genitive singular, the 'of-the' form) of one city, Ephesus. The plural elders are the standing leadership of a single local congregation, and that single local assembly is the addressed unit.

Acts.20.28 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1985 ἐπίσκοπος, G4165 ποιμαίνω, G4168 ποίμνιον, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Force. The same men called 'elders' (presbyterous) in verse 17 are here named 'overseers/bishops' (episkopous, from episkopos, G1985, accusative plural, the direct-object form), set in office by the Holy Spirit, charged 'to shepherd' (poimainein, from poimaino, G4165) 'the church/assembly of God' (ten ekklesian tou theou) over the 'flock' (poimnio, from poimnion, G4168). Elder and overseer are grammatically one office, the same plural cohort under two titles, over one local flock. No higher human officer is named as the source of their charge; the Spirit and the God who purchased the church are. 'Overseer' (episkopos) also appears as a plural in one city at Philippians 1:1, reinforcing local plurality.

1Pet.5.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4850 συμπρεσβύτερος, G4245 πρεσβύτερος

Force. Peter addresses elders as a 'fellow elder' (sympresbyteros, G4850, a hapax, that is a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), not as a ruling bishop above them. The compound levels the writer with the local elders rather than placing him over a graded hierarchy of them, which weighs against a single external bishop ruling congregations from above.

1Pet.5.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4165 ποιμαίνω, G4168 ποίμνιον, G1985 ἐπίσκοπος

Force. Elders are told 'shepherd' (poimante, from poimaino, G4165) 'the flock that is among you' (to en hymin poimnion, from poimnion, G4168), 'exercising oversight' (episkopountes, cognate of episkopos, G1985). The phrase 'that is among you' locates the flock as their own immediate congregation, and the oversight verb again coincides with the elder noun in one office.

1Pet.5.3 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2634 κατακυριεύω, G2819 κληρος, G4168 ποίμνιον

Force. Elders are not to be 'lording it over' (katakyrieuontes, from katakyrieuo, G2634) 'those allotted to them' (ton kleron, from kleros, G2819) but 'examples/patterns' (typoi). 'To lord it over' (katakyrieuo, G2634) is rare (four occurrences, twice of Gentile rulers in Mark 10:42 and Matthew 20:25). The prohibition constrains the manner of governance but says nothing about its scope, so it neither establishes nor rules out trans-local (multi-church) structure.

1Pet.5.4 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0750 ἀρχιποίμην

Force. Christ is the 'Chief Shepherd' (archipoimen, G0750, a hapax, that is a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible, confirmed by direct query as occurring only here) before whom the under-shepherd elders give account. The single supreme head over all elders grounds the Christ-headship clause of the proposition but is silent on whether intermediate human structures exist beneath that headship.

Acts.16.4 · **complicates** · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1378 δόγμα, G2919 κρίνω, G4172 πόλις

Force. Queried morphology (word-form analysis) reads 'the decrees' (ta dogmata, from dogma, G1378, accusative plural neuter, the direct-object form) 'having been decided' (ta kekrimena, from krino, G2919, perfect passive participle, that is a completed action whose result still stands, in passive participle form) 'by the apostles and elders' (hypo ton apostolon kai presbyteron), which they 'were delivering' (paredidosan) to the local assemblies 'to keep/guard' (phylassein) 'throughout the cities' (kata tas poleis, from polis, G4172). A decision made by the Jerusalem assembly is binding and is distributed to the local churches city by city. This is trans-local (across-many-churches) authority reaching into local congregations and is the central datum complicating strict autonomy (self-government independent of any outside authority).

1Cor.7.17 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1299 διατάσσω, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Force. The verse closes 'in all the churches I prescribe' (en tais ekklesiais pasais diatassomai, from diatasso, G1299, present middle indicative first person, that is an ongoing simple statement of fact in first person), with 'to/in the churches' (ekklēsiai, from ekklesia, G1577, dative plural, the 'to/in' form). The identical authority verb that installs local elders in Titus 1:5 is here exercised over all churches simultaneously. The same word spanning both levels is precisely why the vocabulary cannot rank a fully autonomous (self-governing) polity (church-government structure) against a connectional (formally linked) one.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Acts.20.28	1Pet.5.2	openbible	37
1Pet.5.3	Ezek.34.4	openbible	11
Acts.14.23	Titus.1.5	openbible	10
Acts.20.28	Ps.74.2	openbible	8
Acts.20.28	Acts.20.29	openbible	7
1Pet.5.1	1Pet.5.4	openbible	5
Acts.16.4	Acts.15.28	openbible	5

Complicating texts

Acts.16.4 · **addressed**

Direct query confirms 'the decrees' (ta dogmata, G1378) 'having been decided' (ta kekrimena, from krino, G2919, a completed action whose result still stands) by the apostles and elders were delivered to the local assemblies 'throughout the cities' (kata tas poleis) to keep. This is a verified trans-local (across-many-churches) act of binding authority distributed to local congregations, cutting against strict congregational independence. It does not establish a permanent denominational hierarchy, but it does show authority flowing beyond a single local elder body, which is the principal reason the autonomy (independent self-government) claim is recorded as disputed rather than affirmed.

Acts.15.22 · addressed

Query confirms 'it seemed good' (edoxen, from dokeo, G1380) 'to the apostles and the elders together with the whole assembly/church' (tois apostolois kai tois presbyterois syn hole te ekklesia, with 'assembly/church' (ekklesia, G1577) dative singular, the 'to/in-the' form) at Jerusalem, with the 'burden' language (baros, G0922) in verse 28. A conciliar (council-style) body deliberates and decides for assemblies beyond itself. The text shows trans-local conciliar authority without setting up a standing hierarchy, so it qualifies the no-external-authority half of the stem (question).

1Cor.7.17 · addressed

The verb 'to direct/prescribe' (diatasso, G1299) that installs local elders in Titus 1:5 is here exercised over all the churches at once ('in all the churches', en tais ekklesiis pasais). 1 Corinthians 16:1 uses the same verb for the collection across the churches of Galatia. The single vocabulary covering both local and trans-local (across-many-churches) ordering means the words themselves do not delimit the scope of legitimate authority, so the negative clause of the proposition is lexically underdetermined (the words alone cannot decide it).

Acts.9.31 · unaddressed

Query shows 'assembly/church' (ekklesia, G1577) here is N-NSF (nominative singular feminine, the subject form), in NA28, SBL, WH, and Tregelles (modern critical Greek New Testament editions; the verse reads 'the church throughout all Judea and Galilee and Samaria'), while TR (Textus Receptus) and Byzantine (the majority Byzantine text) read the plural 'churches/assemblies' (ekklesiai). This bears on whether the canon (the recognized list of biblical books) speaks of one supra-local (one-church-across-regions) church spanning regions, but the textual split is itself unresolved at the lexical level and the polity-scope (church-government scope) verdict does not turn on it, so it is left open rather than adjudicated here.

Concordance traversed

G1577, G4245, G1985, G4165, G4168, G5500, G2525, G0750, G4850, G2596, G1299, G1378, G2919, G2634, G2819

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

Acts.20.28-theou-kyriou at Acts.20.28: impact none. The 'of God' (theou) versus 'of the Lord' (kyriou) variant ('church of God' versus 'church of the Lord') affects Christology (the doctrine of Christ) and the purchase clause but does not bear on the polity (church-government) question of local elder governance, so the polity verdict is variant robust (the same regardless of which reading is preferred).

Acts.9.31-ekklesia-number at Acts.9.31: impact minor. Critical text reads 'church/assembly' (ekklesia) singular (N-NSF, nominative singular feminine, the subject form, in NA28, SBL, WH, Tregelles, all modern critical editions), TR (Textus Receptus) and Byzantine (majority Byzantine text) read plural 'churches/assemblies' (ekklesiai). This nudges the universal church reading but does not settle the autonomy (independent self-government) scope, so impact on this verdict is minor, not material.

Neither anchor variant falls in the 3 John ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window, so no CBGM (Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, the modern tool for tracing variant relationships) data was examined; this New Testament material is ecm-shadow (outside the published ECM scope). The bundle reported 'not_in_ecm_scope' true with zero variant units, but direct query surfaced the two textual points above, neither of which overturns the polity (church-government) reading.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. congregationalism, presbyterianism, episcopalianism

analogia scripturae invoked

congregationalism: affirms · Reads the distributive 'in every church' (kat' ekklesian) and 'city by city' (kata polin), the elder-equals-overseer identity confirmed across Acts 20:17 and Acts 20:28, the 'fellow elder' (sympresbyteros) self-description of 1 Peter 5:1, and Christ as the sole 'Chief Shepherd' (archipoiemen), as establishing a self-governing local assembly under Christ with no permanent human officer above the local eldership in the text. Treats the Jerusalem decree and apostolic directives as a temporary apostolic foundation, not a standing supra-local (over-multiple-congregations) court.

presbyterianism: disputed · Accepts the local plurality of elders and the elder-overseer identity, but reads Acts 15 to 16 (the binding 'decrees' (dogmata) delivered to the churches), the trans-local (across-many-churches) directive verb 'to direct/prescribe' (diatasso) in 1 Corinthians 7:17, and the coordinated collection across churches in 1 Corinthians 16 and 2 Corinthians 8, as warranting an ongoing connectional (formally linked across churches) authority of assembled elders, so the no-hierarchy clause is not lexically secured.

episcopalism: false · Points to Titus appointing elders 'city by city' (kata polin) under Paul's personal 'I directed' (diataxamen, from diatasso), and to a single delegate installing and ordering elders across multiple congregations, reading the same data as a regional or monarchical oversight pattern in which a single overseer ranks above local elderships, which it takes to contradict strict local autonomy (self-government independent of outside authority).

The positive elements (local plurality of elders, elder equals overseer, Christ as sole Chief Shepherd, 'Chief Shepherd' (archipoiemen)) are lexically secure across all three lenses and are not in dispute. The division is over the negative clause of non-subordination, which the lexicon underdetermines (does not settle on word-evidence alone) because the same authority vocabulary, especially 'to direct/prescribe' (diatasso, G1299) and the conciliar (council-style) 'decree' language of Acts 15 to 16, reaches both the local and the trans-local (across-many-churches) level. Hebrew background texts (Ezekiel 34, Isaiah 56) reinforce the shepherd-flock relation through the cross-references but do not settle polity (church-government) scope.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Examine how the New Testament describes the governance of a local assembly, including who appoints and oversees its leaders, and what relationship, if any, the text shows between one assembly's leadership and any wider authority.

The stem (the question as asked) is verdict-preloaded in two ways. The word 'autonomous' (self-governing, independent of outside authority) and the clause 'not subordinate to a denominational hierarchy or external bishop' assert a contested negative conclusion before the evidence is weighed, and 'denominational hierarchy' and 'external bishop' are tradition-specific targets that the first-century vocabulary does not frame. The verdict was derived on the original stem; the neutral rephrasing isolates the lexical question (who appoints, who oversees, what wider relation) from the polity (church-government) conclusion. VERDICT-CHANGED: no. Verdict unchanged from the prior file: still disputed, now grounded by direct queries that confirmed both the local elder pattern and the trans-local (across-many-churches) decree and directive pattern.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.14.23
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Titus.1.5
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.20.28
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.16.4
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Cor.7.17
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.9.31
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0750
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1299
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Acts.20.28

cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Acts.16.4
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License audit

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STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes

Flags

ecm-shadow · lexically-disputed · complicating-unresolved · cross-tradition-divergent